BOOKS

THE OTHER BOSE

***Fugitive of Empire* delves into the intrepid life of the Indian revolutionary and nationalist Rash Behari Bose and his connection with Japan**

Rash Behari Bose (1886–1945) is prominent in the pantheon of Indian nationalists and freedom fighters. He was a revolutionary terrorist but, as this biography demonstrates, it is his link with Japan, which had a role in the germination of the Indian National Army of Subhas Chandra Bose during World War II, that contributes a different dimension to the violence, non-violence binary that dominates the discourse around Indian nationalism. Rash Behari is also significant because he falls in a select category who gave Indian nationalism a global context.

India's revolutionary movement always loomed large in the imperial mind and in public consciousness. Perhaps Rash Behari was not too different from many of his contemporaries whose nationalist consciousness acquired a cutting edge amidst the outrage that accompanied the partition of Bengal in 1905. An unrelated event—Russia's military defeat by Japan—the same year was equally transformative and awakened in many in India the idea of Asia in opposition to, and distinct from, the Occident and Europe.

What elevated Bose from the other revolutionaries was the audacity of what he attempted and nearly pulled off—assassinating the British viceroy as he entered Delhi at the head of a grand procession in 1912. He became thereafter a major target of British intelligence and, to evade arrest, he escaped to Japan in 1915 where he was to spend the rest of his life.

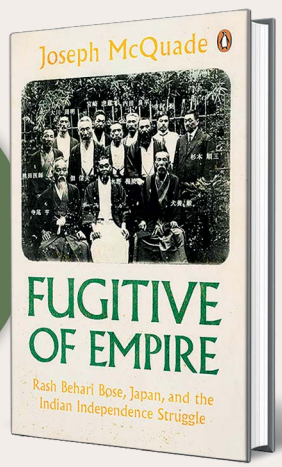
Between 1915 and 1945, Indian nationalism changed from being a debating society and individual acts of violence against the colonial state to a mass movement incorporating different, often opposed, ideas of the nation to come. What also changed was the wider geopolitics surrounding India and Asia. It is a strength of this book that it contextualises this against Bose's unusual perch as an Indian dissident in Japan.

When Bose was trying to settle down in Japan, it was an ally of Britain, and he was often hard-pressed to avoid extradition to India. From the mid-1920s, this position changed with a nationalistically charged Japan convinced that imperial expansion into Korea, China and the rest of Southeast Asia was a vital passport for entry into the club of advanced nations. For Bose, Japan was an Asian power worthy of emulation in India and equally an ally against British colonialism. But this position could often be difficult to maintain in the light of Japanese colonialism in Korea and China: his "pragmatic" endorsement of Japanese imperialism did not prevent him from seeing it also as "problematic". We find in him also an inclination towards religious/Hindu nationalism although, unlike V.D. Savarkar, he supported the Congress's 1942 Quit India movement.

Rash Behari's life in Japan could have ended on a somewhat marginalised note, characteristic of many dissident émigré existences. The transformation of World War II into an Asian and a Pacific war, however, ensured that that did not happen. The raising of the INA in Singapore gave to his life both a dramatic closure and climax, as did handing over Indian nationalism's Japan link to Subhas Chandra Bose. McQuade's book can be read with interest by all those interested in Indian nationalism and intra-Asia connections in an age of imperialism. ■

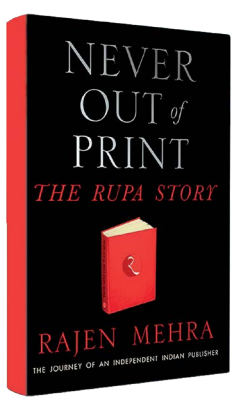
–T.C.A. Raghavan

FUGITIVE OF EMPIRE: Rash Behari Bose, Japan, and the Indian Independence Struggle
by Joseph McQuade
PENGUIN VINTAGE
₹999; 316 pages



It is rare to come across a reader in the English language unfamiliar with Ramachandra Guha. A prolific and elegant writer with major books on modern India, environment, cricket and politics, numerous essays and newspaper columns, he is difficult to ignore or disregard. The journey of an aspiring cricketer and middling academic to a promising scholar and now a 'public intellectual' and patron saint to young scholars makes for a fascinating tale. *The Cooking of Books* is an unusual account of the fortuitous relationship between an author and his editor, one loud, exuberant and opinionated, the other grumpy, acerbic and reclusive, who through episodic meetings and more frequent letter exchanges form a rare and unusually productive partnership.

"Good editors, really good editors, are very



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